and if it took measures to protect its security, the US would oppose efforts of others to interfere with the People's Republic." Huang Hua reiterated that China was prepared to defend itself if attacked. But, concerned that taking any action against India would give the Soviet Union an excuse to attack China, he repeatedly emphasized that Beijing wanted to persist with efforts underway at the UN to resolve the situation.[219]

Did Washington's pressure on Moscow result in the eventual ceasefire? The evolving détente with the US was no doubt a priority for the Soviet Union. But its calls for restraint had preceded US pressure during the war. Since the beginning of the crisis in the spring, Moscow had urged Delhi and Islamabad to find a peaceful solution. It had been concerned for a few years about Beijing taking advantage of any instability in the subcontinent.[220] The signing of the treaty did not result in Soviet officials changing their approach on this front—if anything, they were more concerned since they would inevitably be involved in any conflict. Indeed, when Gandhi had visited Moscow in September, Kosygin had continued to encourage her to find a peaceful solution for this reason.[221] And during the war officials made clear to their Indian interlocutors that their patience was limited.

One unquestionable result of the war was that US-India relations had reached their lowest point. As during the Korean War, China, in confluence with a crisis, had again cast a dark shadow on the US-India relationship. This time around, however, it was because of Washington's—rather than New Delhi's—efforts to engage Beijing. For Gandhi, there was little doubt about this: she told the *New York Times* that America's approach toward India changed "when [its] policy toward China changed."[222]

A Vicious Circle (1972)

In the aftermath of the crisis, Kissinger predicted that India would want to re-establish a working relationship with the US. Gandhi, he believed, would not want to become overly dependent on the Soviet Union. Moreover, India was still in no position to do without external assistance.[223] Kissinger's prediction that US-India relations would soon be better than before the Bangladesh crisis, however, proved wrong.[224]

What followed were months characterized by what Keating called a "vicious circle of actions and counteractions," leaving US-India relations in